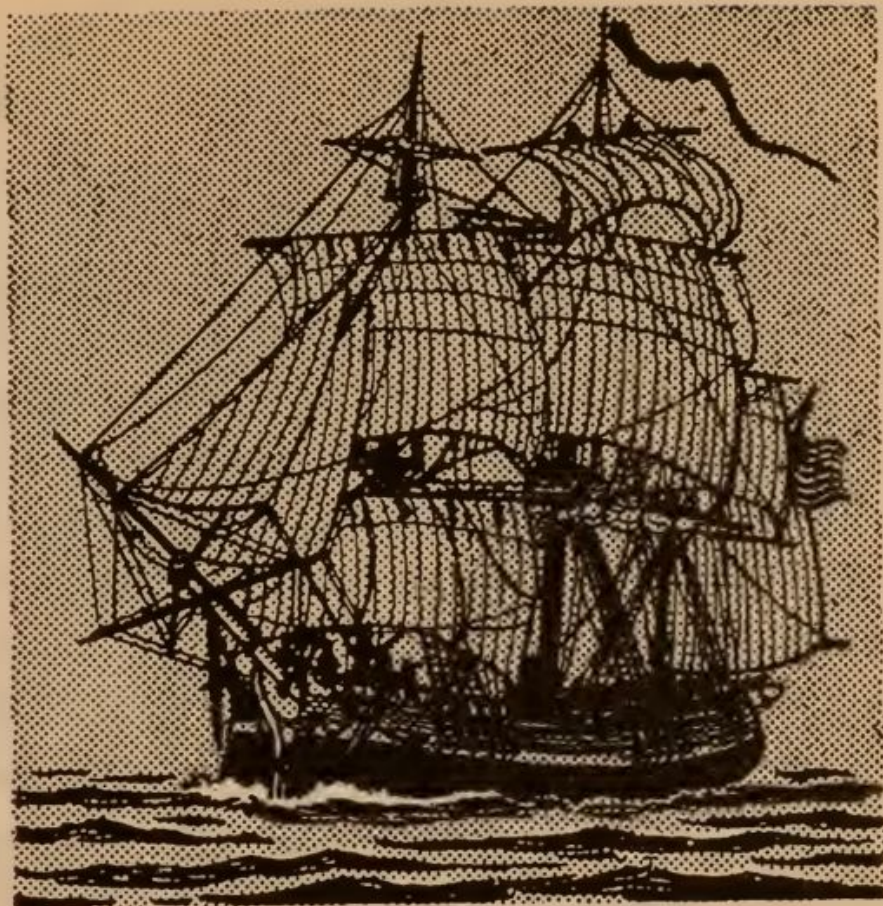


Carry On, Mr. Bowditch

Chapter 24



CHAPTER 24



MAN AGAINST THE FOG

Morning came, but no sunlight. The only way a man could know that day had come was because the fog turned pale. From amidship, a man could not see the bow; he could not even see the foremast. The lookouts strained to see what lay before them, and shook their heads in despair. "If anything's there," one muttered, "we'll find it when we hit it!"

Eight bells came; the starboard watch lay below. In the fo'c'sle the men huddled and slewed sidelong glances at each other. When they spoke they growled in low voices, as though the fog that shrouded the world had muffled their words.

Jensen came below from his trick at the wheel. "You know what the Old Man said to me?" The men looked up without speaking, without moving their heads. "He came alongside me and stood there, watching the compass. He said, 'You have a steady hand on the wheel, Chad; your wake is straight as a string.' "

Corey's voice rose and cracked. "How does he know? Can't see our wake, can we? Can't see anything!"

Jensen nodded. "That's what I said to him. I said, 'Maybe, sir, if we could see it.' Know what he said to me? He said, 'We don't have to see it to know that, do

we, Jensen? We just watch the compass and know. Simple matter of mathematics, isn't it?' And he went below again, cool as you please."

Corey shook his head, as a dog shakes when he comes out of water. "Three days with no sun, no moon, no stars to tell us where we are."

Jensen stopped smiling. "Getting thicker, too." He shook his head. "I'd as soon play blindman's bluff on a cliff as sail through this fog."

Watson stared at the deck. "All right, maybe, if we had sea room. But what do we know about where we are now?"

Corey slumped forward, his elbows on his knees, his hands dangling. "Three days of zigging and zagging. Makes your muscles pull, just thinking about it — how many times we've hauled around on another tack. Zig and zag . . . zig and zag . . . how can a body expect to know where we are?"

Jensen grinned wryly. "We've had plenty practice — most the way home. Ought to be used to it, maybe."

Corey's voice cracked again. "We had sea room then. Sea room! But we were off Nantucket Shoals ten days ago! *Where are we now?*"

Jensen gripped Corey's shoulder. "Easy, lad. Maybe the fog will lift."

But the fog did not lift. Eight bells bong-bonged and it was noon. The fog grew thicker. All around was a ghost world now. From forward, ghost voices of the leadsmen chanted the soundings. From aft, ghost voices spoke as men heaved the log and turned the glass.

The wind freshened and blew in fitful gusts. Jensen said, "Good! It'll blow the fog away!"

It did not. It only blew more clouds of fog to roil and billow over the *Putnam*.

Along about three bells Nat came on deck with his spyglass and went to the larboard rail. The word passed swiftly. "Something's up! The Old Man's taking charge!"

Mr. Denny stood at Nat's shoulder. "Impossible to see anything, isn't it, sir?"

Nat answered without turning. "If the fog lifts one half minute, we can see it."

Mr. Denny stared into the fog, too. The minutes crawled by; the ghost bell marked the leaden-footed time: *bong-bong, bong-bong*. Mr. Denny shifted his feet and sighed. Nat was motionless. His glass never wavered

from the point toward which he stared. The brief day began to darken. Eight bells again; the starboard watch was relieved.

Watson said, "The Old Man's watching for something. S'pose it's the light on Baker's Island?"

Corey shouted, "Baker's Island! Are you crazy? Think we'd get close enough to Baker's Island to see the light in this fog? And fetch up on the rocks somewhere? You crazy fool! Ever seen a ship on Gales Ledge? Or Whale-back? Baker's Island light? You crazy fool!"

Jensen gripped Corey's shoulder again. "Easy, lad. We got sea room. Ain't anywhere near Baker's Island."

Through the white ghost world they heard Nat's voice. "That's it, Mr. Denny! Baker's Island! We're exactly on our course!"

Jensen gasped. Corey whimpered and muttered a prayer. Jensen said, "We'll anchor now, lad. We'll stand off till the fog lifts."

Nat's voice spoke again through the fog. "Two men in the chains, Mr. Denny, and keep heaving those leads!" He moved briskly to the side of the helmsman. "West northwest by west."

“Aye, aye, sir. West northwest by west it is, sir.”

Night came again. Darkness and fog shrouded the *Putnam*. Nat stood near the compass, holding his watch so that he could read the face in the glow of the binnacle lamp.

Watson in the larboard chains sang out, “By the deep ten.”

From the starboard chains Kedzie yelled, “And a quarter less four!”

The helmsman stared at the compass; his knuckles whitened on the wheel.

Somewhere in the mist Corey gasped, "It's shoaling!"

Nat's gaze never left his watch. He lifted one finger, as though with one finger he could control the wind and the waves that hurled a ship, a crew, and three hundred tons of cargo toward the waiting rocks. "Now! Due west!"

"Due west it is, sir."

The minutes crawled. The ship's bell bong-bonged. Kedzie rumbled, "By the deep six."

In the foggy darkness someone tried to laugh, and it sounded like a sob.

Watson sang out, "And a half less six!"

Nat stared at his watch, and he lifted his finger again.
Kedzie yelled, "By the deep four!"

Nat said, "West by north."

The helmsmen swung the wheel hard, growled at himself, and steadied on the course. "West by north it is, sir."

No sound but the ship's bell now.

Watson's singsong came through the darkness. "By the mark five."

And Kedzie's rumble answered, "By the mark five."

Jensen said, "The Old Man goes ahead like it was noonday! He —"

Watson's singsong again. "And a half less five."

Kedzie's rumble answered. "And a half less five."

Watson's voice sharpened. "And a quarter less three!"

Nat gave no sign that he heard. He stared at his watch.

Kedzie's voice again. "And a quarter less three!"

Nat said, "Steady as you go."

Watson yelled, "And a half less three!"

Somewhere in the fog Corey screamed, "It's shoaling, I tell you! We're going aground! We'll be beaten to pieces!"

Nat did not raise his eyes. He hardly lifted his voice to say, "Mr. Sanchez, it would be a kindness if Corey could sleep."



Lem Harvey and Polly Bowditch

Lupe purred, "Aye, aye, sir." In the darkness a fist thudded; a body hit the deck; a slurring scrape said someone was dragging the sleeping Corey forward.

Nat lifted his finger again. "Southwest by south."

In the big white house facing the Common, the tall clock struck nine. Polly rose from her place by the fire, went to the window, shaded her eyes from the light, and stared out into the mist.

Lem Harvey looked up and shook his head. "It's no use, Mrs. Bowditch, ma'am. Won't be any ships make port tonight."

Polly sighed and turned from the window. "I know. But I did so hope he'd be home by Christmas Day."

"Better pray now he don't come."

Polly gasped, "Lem! What do you mean?"

"Nothing, ma'am. Just that the only sailor that'd turn up in Salem tonight would come by land. Because he'd been wrecked somewhere and put ashore."

"Lem, what's happened? What are you keeping from me?"

"Nothing, ma'am."

"There is something," she insisted. "That's why you came tonight. What's happened, Lem?"

His black eyes met Polly's gaze squarely. "I swear, ma'am, it's nothing like that. I just came because — well — I got to thinking about you. I knew the folks was away and you were alone in the house. I just got to thinking about you alone on Christmas night, ma'am. That's all. It's the only reason. I swear it is. You believe me, don't you, ma'am?"

"Yes, Lem, I believe you." For a few minutes she sat by the fire, staring into the glow. Then she was at the window again, staring into the blank wall of fog.

Lem said, "Honest, Mrs. Bowditch . . . "

Polly turned from the window. "I know. You're right, Lem. Of course you're right." She started back to her chair, stopped, whirled, and stood motionless, listening. "I could swear I heard Lupe call out!"

"If you did, ma'am, it was his ghost."

This time Polly clutched his arm and shook it. "Lem! What is it! You've got to tell me!"

Lem stood. "Nothing, ma'am. Only that the *Putnam* ain't coming in. I mean — she ain't coming *tonight!* You got sense enough to know that, ma'am. There's some things a master just don't do. And bringing his ship into Salem Harbor in a fog like this is one! I tell you . . . Where are you going, ma'am?"

Polly didn't answer. She hurried into the hall, flung the big door wide, and stood there, staring into the fog.

From the fog Nat's voice called, "Polly! Is that you?"

"Nat! Oh, Nat, darling!"

He raced up the steps and had her in his arms. "Oh, Polly, it's so good to be home!" After a little he chuckled.

"Good thing you opened the door, though. The fog's so thick I might have gone right past the house!" Still chuckling, his arm around Polly, he closed the door and went in by the fire. "Why, Lem! How good to see you!"

At first Lem didn't answer, he only stared, his jaw sagging. "It's really you! What happened? Where's the *Putnam*?"

Nat tossed off his jacket. "Right down in Salem Harbor, riding to anchor." He stood by the fire, rubbing his hands. "Why?"

"You came in through this fog?"

Polly said, "When it's so thick you almost missed the house?"

Nat shrugged. "Oh, that's different. On the *Putnam* I had log, lead and lookout." He grinned. "Not that the lookout's been seeing much."

Lem growled, "When did you last shoot the sun?"

"About three days ago."

Lem gulped. "Three days? Seventy-two hours? And since then?"

"It's simple mathematics, Lem. At such a speed, in so many hours, you log so many miles in a given direction. It's — "

"Yeah," Lem growled. "Seventy-two hours through the Roaring Forties. Seventy-two hours by dead reckoning, and then you enter Salem Harbor. Why, you . . . begging your pardon, ma'am, for what I'm thinking." He slumped in a chair and stared at Nat.

Nat winked at Polly. "Have you any idea what's the matter with him?"

Polly's eyes danced. "He just doesn't understand about you and mathematics, dear. Two plus two is four. It comes out right, doesn't it?"

Lem shifted in his chair and growled under his breath. Hurrying footsteps thudded on the porch. A heavy fist hammered on the door. Polly went to open it. Zack Selby entered, panting, talking as he came. "I'm sorry about the bad news, ma'am! Someone said they saw him on the street! I'm sorry he lost the *Putnam*, ma'am. He — "

Lem roared, "Come in and stop bellowing, you fool! The *Putnam's* riding at anchor in Salem Harbor!"

Zack stared at Nat. "You — you — come in through the fog? How'd you do it?"

Lem threw back his shoulders and bellowed, "How'd you think he did it? Book sailing! Simple matter of mathematics!" He picked up his jacket and cap. "I'd better explain things to folks, or you two won't get any rest tonight! Come along, Zack!" The door slammed.

Polly's lips quirked. "Lem's going to have a wonderful time." She looked at Nat with glowing eyes. "It's really you! Captain Bowditch, F.A.A. and A.M., I'm very proud of you!" She blinked back sudden tears. "*Oh, Nat, it's been so long!*"

Nat's arm tightened around her. Somewhere out of the past a voice whispered, "*A long time to sail by ash breeze.*"

"Was it awfully hard?" Polly asked.

"Not too bad," Nat told her. "Rough weather sometimes. But I'll say this for it — I was never becalmed!"



